

too much. A possible cure (it's in the experimental stage) is **Options > Preferences > Plugins > Output > DirectSound output**. Select the plugin, click Configure, and under the Buffering tab, tick "Enable CPU usage control".



Make It Sound Better

Winamp sounds decent as is, but for better quality, you might want to try a couple of third-party plugins to both decode audio as well as enhance it. You'll find Enhancer 017, a free DSP plugin that, well, enhances your audio



The Enhancer plugin greatly improves the quality of your audio

here: www.winamp.com/plugins/details.php?id=81361. This is undoubtedly the best DSP plugin you can get for Winamp, and fans have gone so far to say that it makes even your onboard audio card sound like a Creative X-Fi (an exaggeration, we're sure).

Another thing you might want to try is to change your input plugin from DirectSound to waveOut. Do this under **Preferences > Plugins > Output**. The waveOut plugin is dated, but it offers better quality on some sound cards. You could also try a different decoder altogether—the MAD MP3 decoder (www.mars.org/home/rob/proj/mpeg/mad-plugin/), for example.

WINDOWS MEDIA PLAYER 11



Better Searching

Searching your large (and no doubt ever-growing) media library can be as easy as using Google, thanks to WMP

11's search modifiers. For example, you can use "who are you artist: The Who" to search only those tracks sung by The Who. The full list of search modifiers is here, though we wonder who'd be searching for songs by their release date, or by whether it's DRM'd or not. In addition to these, you can use operators like AND, OR and NOT to refine searches. For example, "Pink Floyd NOT Album: The Wall" will get you all tracks for Pink Floyd except those from the album The Wall.

Search

Album Name
Performing Artist
Genre
Song title
Album artist
Music composer
Orchestra Conductor
Contributing artist
Album release date
Length of track in seconds
DRM Protection
Your 1-5 Star Rating
Content Provider

Search Modifier

Album:
Artist:
Genre:
Title:
AlbumArtist:
Composer:
Conductor:
ContributingArtist:
DateReleased:
Length:
Protected:
Rating:
ContentProvider:



Make The Toolbar Notification Fade Out Faster

When you've got WMP running in the toolbar mode, a notification fades in every time you hover the mouse over the toolbar, and then fades out when you move the mouse away. To control the time it takes to fade out, you need to create a Registry DWORD called DeskbandFlyoutTimeout in HKEY_CURRENT_USER\Software\Microsoft\MediaPlayer\Preferences. Set it to 0x0 to stop this deskband from ever appearing, 0xFFFFFFFF to keep it forever, or any value in milliseconds that you wish.



Remember The Song

One of the smarter things about Winamp is that it remembers which playlist and song you were playing when you quit, so the next time you start, all you have to do is push play to resume your playlist where you left it. To duplicate this in WMP, all you need to do is ensure that "Save file and URL history in the player" under **Tools > Options > Privacy** (right-click on the title bar to get to the main menu) is checked.



Rate While You Listen

To rate songs that are currently playing in Windows Media Player, use [Ctrl] + [Windows] + [0–5], depending on what you want to rate it. This nifty little feature works even when WMP isn't the active window, so you don't need to babysit the player if you want to rate your tracks.



Command Line Options For WMP

These are quick ways to get things done from within **Start > Run** itself.

Start WMP with a playlist:

wmplayer /Playlist [playlist name]

Play a song or video:

wmplayer "[filename]"

(add **/fullscreen** if you want it to play in the full screen mode)

Play a DVD:

wmplayer /device:DVD

(add **/fullscreen** if you wish to)

Play a song or video with a certain skin:

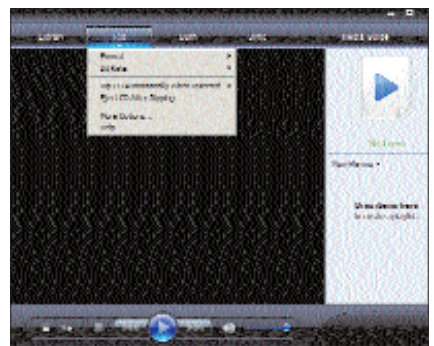
wmplayer "[filename]"?wmpskin=[skin name]"

Open WMP in the Copy From CD Mode: **wmplayer /Task CDAudio**



Getting to grips with the new interface

If you've spent a lot of time with Windows Media Player 10, version 11's minimalistic interface can catch you off-guard for a while—especially the lack of the classic menus. While you *can* enable them by right-clicking the title bar, here's how the new interface is organised—you'll notice that it's more intuitive than it seems.



Right-click on a tab for quick access to options

When you right-click on any of the tabs (Now Playing, Library, etc.), you get a context menu relevant to the activity you would perform in that tab. Right-clicking on Rip, for example, lets you set your rip format and bit rate right there—eliminating the need to go to the classic preferences dialog to set them. You can also get this menu by clicking on the subtle down-arrow button that you see when you roll the cursor over the tab, but the right-click is so much easier.

When you want to add album art to a collection, WMP 11 is simplicity itself—just hunt down the image on the Web, copy it to the clipboard, right-click in the Album art area and choose "Paste Album Art"!